lantern' (a kerosene oil lamp). The space inside it was barely enough for a commode and a towel stand. For the bath there were two buckets placed in a corner, which was raised from the soil with the aid of a few bricks joined together. It was dry sanitation at its simplest. The commode, humourously also called the 'throne' or 'thunder box', would be cleaned every morning by a sweeper, and the bath water would drain out into a temporary underground septic tank nearby. The only consolation was that I was not alone; there were a few more unfortunate souls like me living in that tented colony.

I was attached by the Army Headquarters (HQ) to the Regimental Centre till the commencement of the raising of the 9th Battalion, the Maratha Light Infantry (LI), on 1 October 1964. There were many more young officers posted to the centre at that time. A majority of them were emergency commissioned officers. I was the only NDA graduate amongst all of them, and I held a regular commission. In every combat unit, besides the commanding officer, there were two or three field rank officers, a captain and the rest were subalterns. The joke was that if one threw a stone in the air, it would most probably land on the head of a young officer!

Even though our habitat was frugal, more like the rear area of a war zone rather than a peacetime cantonment in the south of India, we enjoyed all the free time we got. We followed a strict regimen and work schedule at the centre – PT with the recruits at 6.30 a.m., followed by breakfast, supervision of the training of budding soldiers, lunch, and then games with the troops, followed by dinner in the officers' mess. Thrice a week we would have a dinner night – a formal affair for which we had to wear the summer mess kit or the blue patrols in the winter. The menu would generally be a three-course Western meal. The helpings were so small that often we would go to our tents and sleep on a hungry stomach! On all other days, we would cycle down to the club or the town and have a good time. I had bought myself a new cycle, which was the only transport most of us could afford, and that too on monthly instalments. One's